



adhered to that simple guideline have raced ahead of the pack and taken pride of place at the podium. As did the National Law School of India University (NLSIU). Barring one fall in 2005, the university has once again retained its position as the country's premier law school. Ask why, and NLSIU vice-chancellor A. Jayagovind says, with no pun intended, "We are constantly pushing the bar. We want our students to be at the cutting edge."

It's a quality all the winners exhibit, apart from a dazzling array of other attributes that have made them the champions they are. In engineering, in a never-ending game of one-upmanship among the Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs), IIT-Kanpur has grabbed the top slot this year. No doubt this would cause much heartburn among its namesakes in the other cities. But at IIT-Kanpur, apart from focus and cutting-edge, students are encouraged to constantly engage in out-of-the-box thinking. "To be inventive, you need to work outside the conventional framework—even if at times you are ridiculed for it," says institute Director Sanjay Dhande.

Meanwhile, this year's topper in medicine, the All India Institute of Medical Sciences, or AIIMS, (yes, again) focuses on providing excellent infrastructure, state-of-the-art technology, opportunity for research and an enabling environment. AIIMS Director P. Venugopal says, "We inculcate in our students a zeal to excel in their specialisations."

Then, there is Loyola College. That bastion of excellence has emerged tops in two major streams this year, arts and science—an outstanding achievement. The college has a nurturing approach and constantly endeavours to make its students not just good at academics, but also responsible citizens of the country. As Father A. Muthumalai, the Principal, says: "Our key differentiator is the emphasis on the overall development of all our 7,000 students." The Shri Ram College of Commerce (SRCC), the only institute with the unique distinction of topping the commerce ranking for the

11th consecutive year, takes the process even a step further. "The difference we make to students here is to groom them to become global entrepreneurs and not just managers employed in any other organisation," says Principal P.C. Jain.

Now in its 11th year, the INDIA TODAY survey of academic excellence 2007 is perhaps the most comprehensive ever. Last year, for the first time, instead of Top 10, the rankings were extended to the Top 20 for all the six streams—arts, commerce, science, law, engineering and medicine. This year, in deference to requests from many heads of colleges, the survey, for the first time, lists the Top 50 centres of learning in the arts, science and commerce streams. For engineering, law and medicine colleges, the ranks have been extended to include the Top 25. To allow an even more balanced regional representation, two new cities—Jaipur and Kochi—were added to the existing 10: Delhi, Mumbai,

With the inclusion of two new cities, colleges in non-metros have pushed their way into the honours list